

### III: MAIMONIDES' PLACE IN HISTORY

#### CHAPTER VII

#### MAIMONIDES IN THE HISTORY OF THOUGHT

OF all the works of Maimonides the only one we have so far treated in any detail is the *Guide*. Now it is the *Guide* which, outside the Synagogue, determined Maimonides' place in history. Before reverting therefore to Maimonides' interpretation of Judaism, we may well pursue the fortunes of the *Guide* in the general history of thought.

We can distinguish two main epochs in which it made itself felt as a living force, the one at its first appearance in a Latin version early in the thirteenth century, the other on and through Spinoza in the seventeenth. (In the nineteenth century its study was revived, but only as a subject of historical and philological research.) Each of these epochs presents points of interest, which are of more than archæological significance.

#### §

In discussing the *Guide*, I tried to make it clear that it is not a general treatise meant to cover the whole ground whether of religion or of theology. It is directed specifically to the "perplexed," that is, to the puzzled *believer*, and his perplexity arose from the new science. The *Guide's* task was therefore to show that there is nothing in the new science which is irreconcilable with religious belief.

But such perplexities were not confined to the Synagogue. They appeared in the Church too, and under a similar influence. Thus we are told<sup>1</sup> that "in those days [in 1210] there were being studied at Paris certain books, composed, it was said, by Aristotle, which taught metaphysics, books which had

<sup>1</sup> By William Briton, died 1220, ap. Lacombe, *Aristoteles Latinus*, p. 62; cf. Mandonnet, *Siger de Brabant*<sup>2</sup>, p. 13 n.

been brought afresh from Constantinople and translated from Greek into Latin." This new version of Aristotle's *Metaphysics* was not the only one used. There seems to have been an older one going back to the twelfth century, and there was to be a newer one, by William of Moerbek, later in the thirteenth; and the logical and physical treatises of Aristotle had been made known earlier still (cf. above, p. 16). But it was the *Metaphysics*, and particularly its doctrine of God in Book Λ, which proved the disturbing influence, and the intellectual ferment caused by it may be judged by the series of official "condemnations" of philosophical theses in the great theological school of Paris extending from 1210 to 1277.<sup>1</sup> The importance of Maimonides for the "perplexed" within the Church is obvious. Of all the thinkers available to them he was the only one who set out from a similar point of view: Christianity is founded on Judaism, and the two religions share in their use of the Old Testament and in such basic ideas as revelation, creation and the soul. And they share, too, in the difficulties arising from these ideas, and, in the medieval period, they were faced together by the problem of the general relationship between Biblical religion and Greek philosophy. Since, broadly speaking, the impact of Aristotle on Jewish thought came a century before its full entry into the Latin Christian world, the scholastic philosophers found in the Jewish experience summed up in the *Guide* a mature expression of the type of thought they were in search of themselves.

By this is not meant in the least that they were in any sense slavish followers of the *Guide*, although the standard German history of philosophy<sup>2</sup> remarks of Albertus Magnus that "he took over whole chapters of the *Guide* in his works." What is meant is, that they found in the *Guide* the type of question which disturbed them as followers of the Bible and students of Aristotle, and together with it the type of answer which, as followers of the Bible, they could, if not accept, at least consider. The likenesses between Christianity and

<sup>1</sup> See above, p. 15. Those of 1277 are reprinted in Mandonnet, *op. cit.*, pp. 175-191, and commented on by Grabmann, *Der lateinische Averroismus*, Muenchen, 1931.

<sup>2</sup> Ueberweg-Heinze<sup>10</sup>, II, p. 468.

Judaism *vis-à-vis* Aristotle were obviously greater than their differences. It was natural, therefore, for the great Christian thinkers in their struggle with Aristotle to lean on their great Jewish predecessor. And since Judaism was nearer to Christianity than was Islam, more help was likely to be received from Maimonides than from Avicenna or Averroes.

## §

The earliest mentions of Maimonides in scholastic literature are in the writings of William of Auvergne, Bishop of Paris (died 1249), Alexander of Hales (died 1245) and Vincent of Beauvais (died about 1264), and full use of his ideas in the construction of a systematic world view was made by Albert the Great (1193-1280), Thomas Aquinas (1225-74), and, from another point of view, Duns Scotus (1266-1308). The greatest of them all, Thomas Aquinas, would seem to have been indebted to Maimonides<sup>1</sup> for his doctrine on the relation of reason to revelation, on the divine attributes, on God's knowledge, his providence and omnipotence, on creation, and on biblical law; although he seems to have been less sympathetic with Maimonides on the questions of the structure of the universe and of angels and prophecy. The details involved are a matter for specialists and cannot be entered into here (students should refer to the massive and thoroughly documented study of Jacob Guttman in the first volume of *Moses ben Maimon*<sup>2</sup>); yet it may be worth while to adduce from the brilliant address of the late A. E. Taylor on *Saint Thomas Aquinas as a Philosopher* (reprinted in his *Philosophical Studies*, Macmillan, 1934)

<sup>1</sup> See the summary by C. Singer in *The Legacy of Israel*, pp. 267-71; and cf. E. Gilson, *Le thomisme*, 1922, pp. 20, 27, 45, 47, 51, 59, 60, 95, 111, 125.

<sup>2</sup> Vol. I, pp. 135-230, with the caveats of Ueberweg-Heinze<sup>10</sup>, pp. 496-8, where, however, in the course of the attempt to distinguish between them, Maimonides' own theory of the nature of scientific propositions (above, p. 63) is adduced as the "interesting critical remark" of Thomas. See also David Kaufmann, *Der Fuehrer Maimuni's in der Weltliteratur*, 1898 (reprinted in his *Gesammelte Schriften*, 1910, Vol. II); and Julius Guttman, *Einfluss der juedischen Philosophie auf die christlichen Philosophen des Mittelalters und der beginnenden Neuzeit*.

a point which may serve to emphasize what we have seen already:

"Thomas seems first to have attracted attention as a thinker with an individuality of his own," Taylor writes (pp. 235-6), "by his declaration that the philosophical arguments in vogue for an absolute beginning of the world's history will not stand scrutiny and that, apart from a supernatural revelation, it must remain an open question whether the created world has not existed *ab aeterno*, a position in which he agrees with Rabbi Moses. In our own day the bias of metaphysicians seems to be preponderantly in favour of the Aristotelian tenet of the eternity of the world, and the fact stands in the way of our appreciating the originality of this declaration at its full merits. We have to remember that the philosophical bias of the contemporaries of St. Thomas was, quite naturally, in the other direction. . . . To the contemporaries of St. Thomas the assertion that there are no sound philosophical arguments against the creation of the world 'from eternity' involved at least as great a revolution in traditional thinking as the doctrine of the origin of species by natural selection demanded of our grandfathers. It could have come from no one but a thinker of the most marked originality"; a comment which appears just, only the originality would seem to be not of St. Thomas but of Maimonides.

### §

Leaving the vast province of scholastic literature, where only the expert can presume to tread, we may note that much interesting general light is thrown on the whole matter by a brief and curious composition on the *Errors of the Philosophers* (once ascribed to Giles of Rome, and in any case belonging to the latter half of the thirteenth century) reprinted with a special introduction by Mandonnet in the second volume of his *Siger de Brabant*.<sup>1</sup>

<sup>1</sup> The student should be warned against the bad blunder on p. xix, corrected in the article of I. Husik (*Jewish Quarterly Review*, N.S. 1911, p. 159 ff.). Husik, however, seems to have failed to grasp the significance of the book itself.

The "philosophers" whose "errors" are enumerated are Aristotle, Averroes, Avicenna, Algazali, Alkindi and Maimonides ("Rabbi Moyses"). They would seem, as the editor remarks, to have been placed in order not of time but of acceptability, or rather of inacceptability, to the Christian world, Averroes following closely on Aristotle and Maimonides coming last. Apart from obvious points of theology (1-5), Maimonides' errors are as follows: he considers that the celestial bodies are besouled (6); he allows time to begin but not to end (7) and the motion of the celestial bodies to go on for ever (8), nor does he believe in any complete reversal of the world order (9); he thinks that man can dispose himself sufficiently to become a prophet (10); that God cannot make accidents without a subject (11); that apart from man, God's providence is only for the species (12); that God never alters the human will (13); that man can, of his own self, live rightly and fulfil the warnings of the prophets (14); and finally that simple fornication was not mortal sin before the giving of the Law (15). These "errors," which I quote from the summary (cap. xiii), are more fully explained in the preceding chapter, where detailed references are given and where their fuller significance appears. Maimonides is felt to have gone too far in the direction of naturalism. He has conceded too much to the scientists. He leaves no room for "grace" or "miracle" or "sin." His account of human nature does not make divine intervention essential, and he speaks as if man alone can carve out his own destiny. Indeed, as the author somewhat naively complains (p. 23), Maimonides would seem to be even worse than Pelagius!

To the student of Jewish theology all these points are of importance, and they are especially valuable in view of their indirect character. The author of the *Errors* regards Maimonides as a protagonist of Judaism, and Judaism as an imperfect Christianity. The points he picks on are therefore those which in his view divide the mother from the daughter religion, and preclude the Jewish philosopher from perfected faith. He would base religion on the ubiquity of miracle and the paramount necessity of grace, and he condemns Maimonides for accepting the scientific view of the physical world and the

ethical view of the natural man. Yet he is perceptive enough to recognize, in his chapters on the "errors" of Aristotle, that the root-issue between religion and irreligion is that of the eternity of matter and motion, and while he does not mention Maimonides' part in that great argument he is content, with St. Thomas, to follow his lead.

## §

The author of the *Errors* emphasizes one side of Maimonides' teaching, and for him Maimonides erred on the side of positivism. To another great, although less orthodox, thinker of the time, another side was more prominent, and for him Maimonides would seem to have been a light on the path to transcendentalism. The fructifying character of the *Guide* is nowhere more apparent than in the traces it left in the "intellectual" mysticism of Meister Eckhart (1260-1327).<sup>1</sup> Again, it is difficult for the non-expert to express an opinion; yet if one turns to Eckhart's commentary on the Wisdom of Solomon (printed from manuscript sources only in 1928-9) we find "Raby Moyses" quoted time and time again on some all-important theses,<sup>2</sup> and it is again clear that his significance lay in the fact that as an interpreter of Scripture he was acceptable to Christian thinkers.

As such he came gradually to be recognized and accepted as a standard theologian, the thirteenth century translation of the *Guide* being reprinted at Paris in 1520 by the Corsican Bishop Giustiani (friend of Erasmus, Thomas More and Pico di Mirandola), to be studied by such men as Jean Bodin (1530-96), who in his writings on the theory of the state, on historical method and on comparative religion, made full use of the twelfth century master.<sup>3</sup> This version was soon superseded by the new one of Buxtorf issued at Basle in 1629, and

<sup>1</sup> See I. Koch, *Meister Eckhart und die juedische Religionsphilosophie des Mittelalters*, 1928.

<sup>2</sup> *Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du Moyen Age*, III (1928), p. 331, 333, 346, 392, 403; IV (1929), p. 235, 297, 304, 323, 325, 377.

<sup>3</sup> See Jacob Guttman, *Jean Bodin in seinen Beziehungen zum Judenthum*, 1906.

by that time, as is witnessed too by the many editions and versions published of others of his works, Maimonides had become the acknowledged repository of the wisdom of the Synagogue. Yet before passing into the historical pantheon he was destined to quicken European thought a second time through the Dutch-Jewish philosopher Benedict Spinoza.

# §

All students are aware of the profound influence exerted by Spinoza on European thought, yet he was so much out of its normal line of development that a full century had to pass after his death before he attained recognition. It is a twice told story how Spinozism had been a term of reproach (to the great Hume, for example, it was a "horrid hypothesis") until redeemed by Lessing; and Lessing only set it on the path which culminated in the saying (and practice) of Hegel, that to be a philosopher one must be a Spinozist first. Yet the fact remains that the recognition came late, and this fact requires explanation.

Spinoza is generally explained as a disciple of Descartes and a link between Descartes and Leibniz. Yet this would not seem to account for the facts. Leibniz' philosophy was avowedly pluralistic, and there is good reason to think that Descartes' philosophy, both in its basis and in its outcome, was pluralistic too; while Spinozism, whatever else can be said about it, is obviously and obstinately monistic. Both Descartes and Leibniz set out from, and return to, the many; Spinoza from, and to, the one. To trace the real origins of Spinozism means, therefore, to look for the source of his vision of the one.

To the present writer it appears clear that Spinoza's monism is the outcome of the form taken by monotheism in the writings of Maimonides, and that Spinoza's *deus sive natura* ("God or Nature") is a version—possibly a mistaken version and certainly not the only possible version—of the God of Israel. Into this framework, set in his intellectual character with all the intensity of religious belief, he poured the new knowledge of the seventeenth century, just as Maimonides poured into it, with results more in accordance with theological

tradition, the new knowledge of the twelfth. And since the knowledge of the twelfth century was science, however obscure and faltering, the world picture constructed by Maimonides, inspired by his vivid sense both of physical and of religious reality, was of the type demanded by all science, particularly in the great age of science which was the seventeenth century. If one adds to this the further consideration that Descartes in his defence of orthodoxy was drawn into an atomistic theory of time and causation akin to that of the theologians whom Maimonides so vigorously attacked, we shall readily see how close an affinity lies between the leading principles of Maimonides and those elaborated against Descartes by Spinoza. But the walls of Cartesianism did not fall at this one attack and its pluralistic logic had to be worked out through Leibniz and Hume, and its insufficiency stands self-revealed, before Spinozism could come into its own.

Be that as it may, all would agree that Maimonides had *some* influence on Spinoza, and it seems fair to say, in sum, that the basic views of Spinoza in the semi-popular but most influential *Theological-Political Treatise* are developed at least *with reference* to those of Maimonides, while the general spirit of his principal work, the *Ethics*, and certain of its specific teachings, are definitely Maimonidean. (I say Maimonidean because they were common to the whole school which attached itself to Maimonides and with which Spinoza was certainly acquainted.) To speak more specifically, the chapters in the *Treatise*<sup>1</sup> on prophecy, on the prophets, on miracles, and even on the interpretation and general meaning of Scripture, although written in ostensible opposition to Maimonides, are completely dependent on his argument; while in the *Ethics* the stern rejection of all anthropomorphism, the denial of teleology, the theory of knowledge in its three grades, the rigorous conception of law, the insistence on the close connection between physics and metaphysics, and the strongly intellectualist theory of ethics leading up to the doctrines of immortality and the intellectual love of God—all these, as we have seen, are in Maimonides; and to them we must add that

<sup>1</sup> See the admirable monograph of M. Joel, *Spinozas Theologisch-Politischer Traktat*, 1870.

overpowering feeling for the unity and order of the universe which Maimonides expressed so vividly in his attack on the theologians, and which is generally acknowledged to be the keynote of Spinozism.

### §

Indeed, in this point one may sum up the influence of Maimonides on Spinoza as one may that of Spinoza on the world. As we saw earlier, Maimonides' insistence throughout is on the special character of the working of God. God for him, although the ultimate, is not the proximate, cause of everything. He works "through" nature. And nature is a system of law, cause and effect following each other according to rule. This is true, as we saw, not of the physical world only, but of the human world too. God could have changed the character of man by a fiat of his will, but he did not as this is not his way. His way is that each thing, within the whole, should work out its own essence.

That monotheism has ethical consequences is obvious: polytheism divides, monotheism unites. It unites the human race into one family and it unites moral standards into one standard: it allows no appeal (as there was in Greek mythology) to another deity who might think and act otherwise. What is not so obvious (and this is the point so firmly grasped by Maimonides) is that monotheism has consequences for logic and the physical sciences as well. Just as there is only one standard of good, so there is only one standard of truth, and the one truth holds in the unity of the one world. For the monotheism of Maimonides as for the monism of Spinoza the universe is one in the fullest sense of the word. If for Spinoza (e.g. *Cog. Met.* II, 9; *Eth.* II, Lemma 7, sch., III, pref.) "the whole of created nature is only one unique being," so for Maimonides (I, lxxii) "this universe in its entirety is nothing else but one individual being; that is to say, the outermost heavenly sphere, together with all included therein, is as regards individuality beyond all question a single being like Said and Omar. The variety of its substances—I mean the substances of that sphere and all its component parts—is like

the variety of the substances of a human being" (113). "You must therefore consider the entire globe as one individual being which is endowed with life, motion and soul. . . . He who is One has created only *one* being" (p. 115).

This comparison of the body of the universe with the body of man, taken up most significantly in one of the most illuminating of Spinoza's letters (xxxii), is of course not original to Maimonides. Apart from Plato (in the *Timaeus*) and Aristotle himself, it is found in many of Maimonides' Jewish predecessors, most notably in the "Microcosm" (*Olam Katon*) of Joseph ibn Zaddik who was "Dayan" (above p. 17) in Maimonides' birth-place, the city of Cordova, when he was a child but whose book, curiously enough (so he says in a letter), he had never read. What makes the comparison in this chapter of the *Guide* so interesting is the thoroughness of its application. The unity of the body of the universe is one of co-ordination and mutual implication, since "as it is impossible for any part of the human body to exist by itself, not connected with the body . . . , that is to say that the liver should exist by itself, the heart by itself, the flesh by itself, in like manner it is impossible that any part of the universe should exist independently of the other parts in the existing order of things as here considered" (p. 115). Nor are there different forces operative in it. Just as "in man there is a certain force which unites the members of the body, controls them, and gives to each of them what it requires for the conservation of its condition and for the repulsion of injury," so "the universe likewise possesses a force which unites the several parts with each other" (116) and "controls the whole" (118).

"This force is God. It is on account of this force that man is called microcosm, for he likewise possesses a certain principle which governs all the forces of the body. And on account of this comparison God is called [in certain traditional prayers] 'the life of the universe.' " (118)

### §

Maimonides is convinced that this account of the universe "unquestionably agrees with the existing order of things"

(1119), and it can only be emphasized again that for him, as for Spinoza and his followers, religion cannot be divorced from science any more than it can be divorced from morals. The point is epitomized in a well-known confession of faith: "I believe in God, the God of Spinoza, who reveals himself in the orderly harmony of the Universe. . . . I believe that intelligence is manifested throughout all nature. . . . The basis of all scientific work is the conviction that the world is an ordered and comprehensible unity, and not a thing of chance." But this is not only the faith of a great modern Jewish physicist. It is the hoary wisdom of Israel as it came to full fruition in Maimonides. Judaism knows only one God, and that God created one world.

In the one world created by the one God there are human beings who are brought in relation one with another; hence the network of personal and social life: in brief, conduct and morality. But human beings are brought into contact not only with one another but also with the world itself. They study its structure and environment; seek to determine its parts and limits; bring it into relation both to man and to itself. And this is science, not the practical study of how man can live with man in the world, but the theoretical study of how the "wheels" of the world in which man lives "go round." But in either case it is one and the same man; and it is also one and the same world.

Now the Kantian view in morals, representing largely, and largely represented by, certain forms of Christianity, tends to throw obstacles in the way of science (i.e., the physical and biological sciences, not mathematics). Any dichotomy is liable to do this, and for an obvious reason. If we fix our eyes, with Plato, for example, on the perfections of another world, we are bound to weaken our interest in this; and history, beginning with Aristotle, says that this was precisely what happened to the Platonic school. What is true of perfection in general is true of moral perfection as well. If we fix our eyes too determinedly on abstract moral goodness, we are bound to notice that it is not to be found in this world and flee perforce to another. This world thus becomes only a shadow of the eternal and has as little place for truth as for goodness.

Such a view is not acceptable to the tradition of Jewish thought. In the beginning God created all that is; man is a part of the creation; God is both goodness and truth. Thus the fundamental structure of the Jewish attitude not only did not forbid the study of physical nature, it allowed it, even encouraged it: "Lift up your eyes on high and *see who hath created* these." Judaism is not concerned solely with the moral attitude in life and towards life. It is concerned, possibly principally, with morals, but only in such a way that science should not be disavowed.

Herein lies the special contribution of Judaism and Jewish thought to the intellectual puzzlement of modernity. It is associated historically with the medieval development of Biblical teaching which found its fullest expression in Maimonides. It is associated with the development of the teaching of Maimonides which is to be found in the philosophy of Spinoza. In more recent times it may be coupled with the names of such thinkers as Bergson, Alexander and Einstein. If we consider these great Jewish thinkers on the one hand and the historic faith which is Judaism on the other, we may perhaps adapt a famous phrase of Kant and sum up by saying: religion without science is empty; science without religion is vain.